appeared at the court of the Han Dynasty and its successors. Representatives of the land of Wa were recorded as first arriving in Eastern Han in the year 57 CE, though some accounts place the first encounters between Chinese and Japanese communities as far back as the late second century BCE. Not surprisingly, these earliest references to Sino-Japanese relations are in the context of China's intervention on the Korean Peninsula, with which ancient Japan had long-standing exchanges. Nor would an observer at the time be shocked by the letter from the Wei court quoted in the epigraph at the beginning of this chapter. Wei's expectation of deference is natural, as it was one of the three major post-Han states of the Three Kingdoms period in China (220–280 CE), successor to a great empire. Perhaps slightly more surprising is the letter from "empress" Suiko to the Sui Court. Supposedly written by the legendary Prince Shotoku, it reflects an upstart island nation just beginning to unify itself in the seventh century, asserting not merely equality but superiority over Asia's most powerful country.

The broad contours of Sino-Japanese relations thus became clear early on: a competition for influence, an assertion by both of their respective superiority, and an entanglement with Asia's geopolitical balance. Despite the passing of two millennia, the base of this relationship has changed little. Today, however, a new wrinkle has been added to the equation. Whereas over the previous centuries only one of the two nations generally was powerful, influential, or internationally engaged in any given era, today both China and Japan are strong, united, global players, well aware of the other's strengths and their own weaknesses.

Most American and even Asian observers presume that it is the Sino-American relationship that will determine Asia's future, if not the globe's, for the foreseeable future. Yet the competition between China and Japan has been of far longer duration, and its importance should not be underestimated. As the United States debates its global role after its wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, as it continues to struggle to maintain its widespread global commitments, and as the full scope of Donald Trump's desired readjustment of US foreign policy continues to take